

Switzerland Itinerary

By Desk2Destinations

desk2destinations.com

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Zurich: A Conference, a Cultural Shock & Dinner in the Clouds

Zurich was, honestly, the city that gave us our first proper **cultural shock** of the trip — the moment we realised Europeans were quietly enjoying life on a level we hadn't quite seen anywhere we'd grown up. But Zurich on this leg wasn't a leisurely city break. It was the working part of the trip. **Harshit had a conference at the Marriott**, and Zurich was our base for two days — except we weren't really in Zurich. We were in **Dietikon**, a quieter suburb a short train ride out, sharing an apartment with our friends **Kapil and Sam**, who'd come up from Germany to meet us.

So this is less a sightseeing diary and more an honest little record of two days squeezed between presentations, lake-side wandering, one disappointing chocolate factory, and one very memorable dinner on top of the only skyscraper in the city.

Day 1

FlixBus Arrival, Marriott Registration & the Lindt Disappointment

We rolled in on the **FlixBus from Bercy Seine** after a hard goodbye to Paris — two bus changes to even get to the bus station, a long ride packed with Indians living in both cities, and a hungry, heavy-hearted arrival. We linked up with Kapil and Sam, and our first stop wasn't even the apartment — it was the **Marriott**, to complete Harshit's conference registration. The Marriott washroom was great. The Marriott's pricing was less great: they told us I'd have to pay **75 euros separately** if I wanted to attend the conference dinner. Noted.

The **Zurich travel ticket** I'd been counting on turned out to be useless for the routes we needed, so we had to drop our planned **Rhinefalls and Limmat cruise** right there. Instead, all four of us caught a train down to **Kilchberg** for the **Lindt factory**. We ate lots of chocolates. Lots. The next discovery was less sweet: **Lindt chocolates are not cheaper in Switzerland than in India**. We left with two small packets and a quiet sense of having been pranked by our own expectations.

We strolled the Zurich lakeside, ate lunch by the water, swapped stories — Kapil and Sam about Germany, us about Paris — and then headed back to **Dietikon** to rest. Two things went wrong on arrival: both Harshit and I had forgotten the exact building, and we'd taken the wrong bus. We eventually found the apartment, ate pav bhaji and pasta (Kapila helped cook and clean up), and they gifted us chocolates. We left to find dinner and stumbled on **Doner** on Kapil's phone internet — properly fulfilling, and I packed one for the next day's breakfast. Saw them off at **Zurich HB**, came back to Dietikon, and slept the heavy sleep of someone whose husband has a major presentation in the morning.

Day 2

Harshit's Presentation, a Long Afternoon Alone & Dinner at CLOUDS

17th August 2022 — Harshit's main day. He left early. I slept a bit more, then got ready and reached the conference hall **ten minutes before his slot**. Recorded the video. He presented well. After that, the sessions stopped making sense for me — it's been a while since I sat through a technical conference, but it had never happened before that I went completely blank. So I left.

I walked to **Zurich lake** — it's within walking distance of the Marriott — and sat there with a sandwich and a coke, watching the weather and the boats. Eventually I got a little bored and went back to the hotel, claimed **a corner of the first-floor lobby**, and that corner became my world from **12 pm to 6**

pm. I wrote my Europe diary. I watched Netflix until my laptop battery died. I attended an "Innovation" session that, honestly, was boring. Then we got ready in the bathroom for the evening.

CLOUDS is the only skyscraper in Zurich, and the restaurant sits right on top of it. 75 euros for the dinner — and worth it. Lots of Indians, a big group photo, and the whole conference crowd letting go for one evening.

We took a tram up to **CLOUDS** for the conference dinner. It's the only skyscraper in Zurich and the restaurant is on top of it — 360-degree city light below, and the kind of dinner that makes 75 euros stop feeling like a number. Lots of Indians, a long group picture, food we actually enjoyed. We came back to Dietikon, packed for the next morning's train to Bern and Interlaken, and slept.

An Honest Take: Cultural Shock, Expensive City, Quieter Base

Zurich was our first city after landing into the German-Swiss leg, and writing this from the Marriott lobby that long afternoon, what kept hitting me was: *"European people know how to celebrate life. They are not earning to enjoy life with family. They are enjoying life and earning to survive. Completely opposite to the mindset I have been raised in."* I should not complain about my upbringing, but I do aspire to adopt some of that.

Practically — Zurich is expensive in a way that catches you off guard if you've been getting away with it in Prague or even Paris. The travel ticket trap cost us Rhinefalls. The Lindt pilgrimage was charming but not the bargain we'd imagined. Staying out in **Dietikon** with friends was the right call — quieter, cheaper, and turned the trip into a proper hangout instead of a hotel stay. If we ever come back, we'd come back for the lake, the Rhinefalls we missed, and one more dinner at CLOUDS.

Must-Visit (and One We Missed) in Zurich

- **CLOUDS:** Zurich's only skyscraper rooftop restaurant — 75 euros, fully worth it for the view alone.
- **Lindt Factory, Kilchberg:** Eat all the samples; don't expect cheaper prices than India.
- **Zurich Lake (Zürichsee):** Sit, eat a sandwich, watch the boats — free, quietly perfect.
- **Dietikon as a Base:** Stay out here if you want quieter, cheaper, and an actual apartment vibe.
- **Doner near Zurich HB:** Cheap, filling, the right kind of street food.
- **Rhinefalls:** We had to skip this — the Zurich travel ticket didn't cover it. Buy the right ticket and go.
- **Limmat Cruise:** Also skipped, also on the list for next time.
- **Zurich HB:** Worth a walk around — Switzerland's busiest station and unreasonably clean.

Interlaken: The Skydive That Wasn't, and the Day the Cards Stopped Working

We arrived in **Interlaken** from **Bern** on the evening of 18 August 2022, looked up at the sky and saw paragliders drifting in slow spirals over the meadow. Harshit and I grinned at each other like idiots. The skydive was booked for the next morning. This, we thought, was going to be the highlight of two weeks in Europe.

What we got instead was a Thun cruise in a drizzle, a village in the clouds, a cancelled jump, and a small financial nightmare at a Grindelwald souvenir shop. Two days that the diary has more words for than any other stop on the trip. Here is the honest version.

Day 1

Bern Stopover, a Thun Cruise and the Mürren Cable Car

We had taken the morning train towards **Interlaken** and got down at **Bern** on a whim, to see the Einstein Museum and Apartment. It was nostalgic, overpriced and not really worth the money, but we walked off the disappointment with a burger and some Läderach chocolates near the station. Bern, the capital, felt like a quieter Prague — police on horseback, fountains, parks, no rush. Then we boarded onwards.

As the train pulled into Interlaken, the sky was full of tiny coloured kites — paragliders coming down toward the meadow. We got thrilled all over again for the next day's **skydive**. Honestly, after Zurich and Lucerne, this was a different league. **Interlaken is way better than Zurich & Lucerne**, and I will say it to anyone who asks.

The tourist office helped us slot two big things into one half-day. A short train ride took us to the pier, where we caught a **boat cruise of Thun** just in time. We sat up on the deck as the lake rolled past castles and lakeside villages. By the end of the cruise the first drops of drizzle began — the very start of the less-sunny, more-rainy weather that would chase us for the rest of the trip.

From there we took a cable car and then a small train climbing on great height up to **Mürren**. The villages in Interlaken are really beautiful. The greenery, the mountain views, the sheer scale of it — it is mesmerising for a tourist like me, who has come from a place where finding serenity even in the mountains is not easy. Mürren *gives you the impression that you are lost in mountains*. By the time we climbed back down, it was raining properly and we were tired. We headed for the Airbnb.

The Airbnb Couple Who Turned Their Study Into Our Room

An elderly lady greeted us at the door and, unlike in Paris, this time we actually met our owner. The room she had given us was very cute — they had turned their study room into a guest room. Books on the shelves, a Mac on the desk, family photos capturing their important memories, one big globe with a light inside, a cozy bed, and one piece of welcome chocolate placed on the pillow. The kind of room you do not want to leave.

The next morning, when our Maggie water proportions got messy and I had to ask her for help with the microwave, we stepped into the host couple's actual living space — and that was the real picture.

Music instruments, glass sculptures, a couch, music playing, and an L-shaped modular kitchen with a glass view of the whole room and the garden outside the wall. Swings in the garden. Picture perfect, really.

There was a clear language barrier — she did not have much English, we had no German — but she tried her best to make us comfortable, asked about our skydive plans, lit up when we explained. I left their flat with one line stuck in my head: *the warmth of people around the globe makes this planet worth giving a shot to save humanity.*

Day 2

The Skydive That Wasn't

The morning of 19 August started with a breathtaking view from the window — rain, dark clouds, mountains, lake. Breathtaking and heartbreaking in the same breath. The phone buzzed. **All slots got cancelled.** Our skydive was off.

I tried to pivot quickly — maybe we explore something close by — but Harshit, deflated, went back to sleep. We ended up leaving the room only around noon, well past the gentle check-out time. I made Maggie awkwardly in the host's microwave (the proportions were wrong, she patiently helped), and I could sense her husband getting a little worried about how late we were running. We took our luggage, stood under a roof outside the house, ate the Maggie in the drizzle, and stared at the same view that had cost us our jump. Then we made a plan. If the sky was going to keep us on the ground, we would at least move sideways. We picked Grindelwald.

Grindelwald in the Rain, and Three Cards That All Said No

The train to **Grindelwald** climbed slowly through grey weather, dark clouds wrapped around the mountains. Somewhere along the way we passed the stop for **Jungfrau** — the Top of Europe, the most expensive mountain in the region — and I quietly thanked God we had not booked it. On a day like this it would have been pure cloud, freezing cold, and a small fortune evaporated. We were saved by accident.

Grindelwald itself, on a day like that, is a small village wrapped in clouds. Beautiful for ten minutes, then gloomy and cold. We wandered into a souvenir shop and picked out two things: a pen for Harshit's guide back home and a small salt box for the house. And then came the part of the day that the diary will not forget.

Our cash was almost over. We tapped a card — declined. Tried the second — declined. Tried the third — declined. The shopkeeper was rude about it. We left the salt box on the counter (we were just two euros short), took only the pen and walked out, convinced his machine was glitching. It wasn't. At the pizza cafe down the street we ate, ordered, and then watched the same scene replay. Three cards, three declines.

Three cards in three machines. All declined. No cash, no working plastic, a bill on the table and a village full of strangers. Worst feeling we have ever had as travellers.

The cafe owner saved us with patience. He let us sit, opened his free wifi, and waited while we figured it out. The only card that finally pulled cash from an ATM was our **SBI** debit card. The other bank's system — SBM — was down for hours (they confirmed it later by email). For any Indian reading this, the line we kept repeating that evening was simple: *SBI saved our reputation.*

We missed our intended train because of all that drama. With time to kill, we walked into **COOP** — the Swiss supermarket chain — and discovered that the same small salt box from the rude shop was sitting on the shelf for two euros less. We bought it, plus a stack of chocolates, and felt a small petty victory through the gloom.

The Panoramic View Train to Gstaad and Onwards to Montreux

At the station we ran into Pooja, Neha and Udit again — the friends we kept bumping into on this trip — and we all boarded together, parting ways at the next interchange. They went up towards **Mürren**. We took two different connecting trains to catch the **Panoramic View train** heading toward **Gstaad**, the village made famous in India by DDLJ. We reached the platform with seconds to spare.

And then, finally, the sky cracked open. Sunshine. The Panoramic carriage with its huge curved windows framed valleys, lakes, and tiny chalets sliding by like a film reel. I will say it plainly: *no matter how costly Switzerland is, their train transport is impeccable*. Just so good that one should experience it.

The ride was so good we did not even get down at Gstaad. We rode straight through to **Montreux**, which is just about an hour before Geneva. Harshit's senior had asked us to come to Geneva, but we skipped it — we wanted these last hours to be slow. Two hours by the lake in Montreux, one final European pizza with drinks, and then the long train back to Zurich. The next morning at 5am we would leave Dietikon for the flight home. But the train window all the way to Montreux is the picture I keep when I think of Interlaken.

Must-Visit Places (and One Hard-Earned Tip) for Interlaken

- **Lake Thun cruise:** An afternoon on the deck with castles sliding past — do it before the rain starts.
- **Mürren cable car & train:** The village that genuinely feels like getting lost in the mountains.
- **Paragliding over the valley:** Book early — we saw them from the train and instantly wanted to jump.
- **Skydive (weather permitting):** Magical when it runs, devastating when it cancels — always have a backup day-trip plan.
- **Grindelwald village:** Postcard pretty in sunshine, atmospheric in cloud — either way, an easy train ride.
- **Panoramic View train towards Gstaad / Montreux:** The cheapest "experience" in Switzerland that feels priceless.
- **COOP supermarket:** For chocolates, souvenirs and salt boxes at a fraction of tourist-shop prices.
- **Carry an SBI & SBM card combo:** From bitter experience — one Indian bank's system *will* be down. Have a second issuer in your wallet.

Lucerne: Chapel Bridge, a Weeping Stone Lion & the Cog Up Pilatus

If **Zurich** is the city that works and **Interlaken** is the launch pad, **Lucerne** is the postcard. Or rather, it's a real city that has the temerity to actually look like the postcards — wooden covered bridge with a stone water tower, swans on the lake, painted houses leaning over the river, and the snowy bulk of **Mount Pilatus** bulking up at one end of town like a stage backdrop someone forgot to remove. We came in on the train from Interlaken in the morning and were on a lake steamer by mid-afternoon.

Two nights felt about right. It's a small old town and you can cover the headlines in a single dedicated day, but the joy of staying over is the evening — when the day-trippers from Zurich have gone home and the bridge and the riverbanks belong to whoever's still around.

Day 1

Chapel Bridge: The Wooden Heart of the Old Town

The **Kapellbrücke** — Chapel Bridge — crosses the river Reuss at an odd diagonal, ducks past the octagonal stone **Wasserturm** (water tower) at its midpoint, and is hung internally with a series of 17th-century triangular paintings tucked up under the rafters. It is the oldest surviving wooden covered bridge in Europe, originally built in 1333, though a chunk of it burned down in 1993 and was carefully rebuilt — you can spot the slight colour difference in the timbers if you look.

We crossed it probably six times in two days. At night, with the painted houses on the far bank lit up and the swans gliding underneath, it is unapologetically romantic, and the kind of thing that makes you not even mind the small crowd that's also trying to photograph it. The slightly less famous wooden bridge a little further downstream, the **Spreuerbrücke**, is darker and quieter with a medieval Dance of Death painted along its beams — go for the atmosphere.

Day 1

The Lion Monument: A Carving That Stops You

Mark Twain called the **Lion Monument** "the most mournful and moving piece of stone in the world," and he was, annoyingly, exactly right. Carved directly into a cliff face in a quiet park a short walk from the centre, the dying lion — pierced by a spear, head fallen onto its paws — commemorates Swiss Guards killed defending the Tuileries in the French Revolution. It is shockingly large and shockingly tender at the same time.

We turned up expecting a quick photo and a tick. Instead we sat on the bench opposite for fifteen minutes. Free to visit, easy to find, do not skip it.

You round the corner half-expecting a bit of garden statuary, and instead a wounded ten-metre lion is looking quietly back at you out of the rock. Then you understand why people whisper here.

Day 2

Mount Pilatus: The Dragon Mountain by Cog Rail

The classic Lucerne mountain day is the **Golden Round Trip up Mount Pilatus** (2,128 m): a lake steamer from Lucerne to **Alpnachstad**, the world's steepest cogwheel railway up the side of the mountain (gradients up to 48% — your stomach notices), an hour or two on top with viewing terraces and a couple of short ridge walks, then down the other side by two cable cars and a gondola back to

town. It's a fully-engineered Swiss day, and it works.

We picked a morning where the cloud was sitting just below the summit, broke through it on the cog rail, and emerged into clear sun above a sea of white — the kind of view that justifies several hundred Swiss francs without you needing to ask. If Pilatus is fully clouded, the alternative is **Mount Rigi** ("Queen of the Mountains"), reached by an equally lovely combination of boat and cog rail, with gentler trails on top and slightly cheaper tickets.

Day 2

The Lake Lucerne Steamer: Slow Travel That's Worth It

Don't leave town without doing some time on **Lake Lucerne**. The fleet still includes several restored paddle steamers, and there's a particular pleasure in standing on the wooden deck of one of those, watching the great red paddle wheel turn, while the mountains on either side slide past. We took a short loop out to **Weggis** and back one afternoon, ate apple strudel on board, and decided this was, all things considered, an excellent way to spend a few hours of a life.

The Old Town itself rewards a slow wander after dinner. The **Hirschenplatz** and surrounding squares are flanked by buildings entirely covered in painted frescoes — guild signs, allegories, hunting scenes — and the medieval **Musegg Wall** with its nine towers rises just behind the centre; several towers are free to climb in summer for some of the best, least-crowded views in town.

Must-Visit Places in Lucerne

- **Chapel Bridge at Night:** Lit up, painted houses behind, swans below.
- **Spreuerbrücke:** The darker, quieter wooden bridge.
- **Lion Monument:** Free, short walk, do not skip.
- **Mount Pilatus Golden Round Trip:** Boat, cog rail, cable cars.
- **Mount Rigi:** The plan-B mountain, gentler trails.
- **Lake Lucerne Paddle Steamer:** A short loop, top deck, strudel.
- **Musegg Wall Tower Climb:** Free, panoramic, often empty.
- **Old Town Frescoed Squares:** Hirschenplatz and Weinmarkt at dusk.

A Few Hours in Bern: Einstein's Overpriced Flat & a Capital That Feels Like Prague

Bern wasn't really planned. We were on the train from Zurich to Interlaken, eating our final box of chole chawal on board, when we decided to get down at Bern just for the **Einstein Museum and Apartment**. A few hours, a quick walk, back on a later train to Interlaken. That's all it was meant to be — and that's basically what it was.

Short as it was, Bern left a strong impression — partly because of the streets and the fountains, and partly because of one quiet, slightly grumpy realisation: the place we'd come specifically to see was the part we enjoyed least.

Morning Arrival & the Einstein Apartment

We were a bit late as usual but caught our train, ate our last **chole chawal** on board, and got down at **Bern** because of **Einstein**. The plan was the museum, but on the way we hit the **Einstein Apartment** first — Kramgasse, the room above a café where he lived during his miracle years.

Honest verdict: it's okay, and it's highly overpriced. There's some nostalgia to it — standing in a small room with his desk and his window — and the view out from the apartment is genuinely nice. But it was not worth the money we paid. If you've come for a quick wave at history, fine; if you've come expecting a real museum experience, manage expectations.

Old Town: Police on Horses, Fountains & Läderach Chocolate

It turned into a strangely hungry day. On the way to Einstein's place, we ate a burger. On the way back to the station, we ate a **different croissant** (not the Paris kind — flakier, lighter, somehow more buttery) and stocked up on the famous **Läderach chocolates**. The shopkeeper told us they were planning to open a store in India — note for any 2022 readers reaching this from the future: that's now actually happened.

The stroll through the old town was the actual highlight. **Police patrolling on horseback**, painted fountains at every other corner, a small park, the museum building, the long sandstone arcades that let you walk most of the centre without looking up. We didn't climb the Zytglogge or queue for the Bear Park properly — we just walked, ate, photographed, and made our train.

Bern Feels Like Prague (with Fewer People)

"Bern, capital of Switzerland, gives you complete feel of Prague with less people."

That's the line I wrote in my diary on the train out, and I still stand by it. The colours of the buildings, the cobbled lanes, the slightly medieval weight of it — it all rhymes with Prague, but emptied out. Where Prague was loud and crowded and full of bachelor parties, Bern was almost sedate. Capital city, sure, but capital city the Swiss way: quiet, well-organised, expensive, and not particularly interested in showing off. We boarded the train onward to Interlaken with the sun out and the Läderach in the bag, and that was Bern done.

Must-Visit (and One to Skip) in Bern

- **Einstein Apartment, Kramgasse 49:** Go if you must — but know it's nostalgic and overpriced.
- **Old Town Arcades (Lauben):** Walk the whole centre under sandstone arches.

- **Läderach Chocolate:** Buy a box. Worth the suitcase weight.
- **Zytglogge Clock Tower:** The astronomical clock show — we only saw it from outside.
- **BärenPark:** Live bears beside the Aare; we passed but skipped the queue.
- **The Painted Fountains:** Just keep walking — they're everywhere, and weirdly charming.

Two Hours in Montreux: A Panoramic Train, Lake Geneva & Our Last Meal in Europe

Montreux was never on the plan. It was the accidental last stop of a fifteen-day Europe trip — a town we landed in because the Panoramic View train from Interlaken was so beautiful that we just *kept going*. We were meant to get down at **Gstaad**, the village made famous to every Indian by *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*. We didn't. We rode it an hour further to Montreux, one stop short of Geneva, sat by the lake for two hours, ate a pizza, and turned around.

This isn't a deep-dive guide. It's a two-hour stopover, honestly told.

Arriving by the Panoramic View Train

The morning began in the rain at **Grindelwald** with three cards getting declined at a shop, our SBI debit card finally bailing us out at COOP, and a missed train. We caught the next one and connected onto the **Panoramic View train** from Interlaken. Two trains to reach it, on time by a thread. Switzerland's train transport, no matter what it costs, is genuinely impeccable — that's the line I keep coming back to.

The PV train climbs slowly through alpine pre-mountains, and just as it began, the **sun finally came out** for the first time in days of grey, rainy Swiss weather. The view, the sunshine, the carriage windows — everything was so good that we never got down at Gstaad. We kept going till the line ended at **Montreux**, one hour short of Geneva. **Lake Geneva** opened up below us on arrival.

Two Hours by the Lake & Our Final Meal in Europe

We checked the timetable for the train back to Zurich, then walked down to the lakefront with two hours to spend. We found a place and ordered **pizza and drinks** — and that turned out to be **our final meal in Europe**.

"We were literally roaming like European citizens but deep down in the evening we knew we have to leave tomorrow & we are temporary here. Two weeks flew just like that."

That's exactly what it felt like. The palm trees, the lake, the French Alps on the far side — the whole gentle, lake-resort grace of Montreux, all of it borrowed for two hours before we had to head back to Dietikon, pack, and catch a 5 am taxi to the airport.

What We Skipped (So You Know What This Page Isn't)

To be straight with anyone using this page to plan: we didn't actually *do* Montreux. The classic stops were all skipped:

- **Château de Chillon** — the famous castle on the lake. Didn't go.
- **Geneva** — only an hour away by train. Didn't go. Harshit's senior had invited us but the timing didn't work.
- **Freddie Mercury statue / Queen Studio Experience** — the Montreux pilgrimage. Didn't do it.
- **Lavaux vineyards, Vevey, Rochers-de-Naye** — all the proper day trips. None of them.

The stop was about catching the train back to Zurich for the flight home. So treat this as a brief stop, not a guide. If you actually have two days here, you'll have a much fuller story to tell than ours.

Montreux Checklist — What We Did vs. What We Missed

- **Lake Geneva Lakefront:** We did this — and it's enough on its own for two hours.
- **Pizza by the Lake:** We did this. Our last meal in Europe.
- **The Panoramic View Train In:** We did this — possibly the highlight of the day.
- **Château de Chillon:** We missed this. Top of the list for next time.
- **Freddie Mercury Statue & Queen Studio Experience:** We missed this. Bring a rose.
- **Day trip to Geneva:** We missed this. One hour on the train.
- **Lavaux Vineyards:** We missed this. UNESCO-listed, walkable, photogenic.

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